

stomatology (mouth), ophthalmology (eyes), neurology (nerve disorders) and gynaecology (pregnancy-related) have started to pick up. “We maintain our positive view on chronic focussed companies...,” the firm said in a recent report.

According to the analysis by Rao and Varia, in August 2022 the Indian pharmaceutical market (IPM) grew 12.1 per cent year-on-year (YoY), largely led by price hikes (6.6 per cent), volumes (4 per cent), and with some growth coming from product launches (1.5 per cent). “The base month of July 2021 had no major impact from Covid-19, with a majority of all therapies returning to normal,” says the report, further adding that in the past 12 months, the moving annual total (MAT) of the IPM has grown at 6.3 per cent YoY. Barring anti-malarial and anti-infective therapies, most other major non-Covid-19 categories grew in double digits, including respiratory, central nervous system and cardiac, which together form around 26 per cent of the IPM. Some other categories also saw double-digit growth (see *Booster Dose* for details) including chronic (pre-existing or long-term illnesses) and acute therapies (for short-term illnesses such as respiratory ailments, cold and cough or flu).

That is not to say that Covid-19, and its impact on the pharma industry, is totally gone. While there has been a slide in demand for Covid-19 vaccines produced by companies like Serum Institute of India (SII) and Bharat Biotech, other drugs used in the management of mild, moderate and severe Covid-19 such as

the pandemic. This trend is likely to go on for about three months more and may level off to pre-Covid-19 status. About 90 per cent of patients with diabetes are on medication, and those with long duration of diabetes [are] on multiple medications and insulin,” says Dr Anoop Misra, Chairman of the National Diabetes, Obesity and Cholesterol Foundation, and President of Diabetes Foundation (India). Misra, also the Chairman of Fortis C-DOC hospital in Delhi, says there were many more patients with uncontrolled diabetes during the second wave of the pandemic, since these patients were severely affected with Covid-19 and most were on steroids. “There was an increase in medicine consumption during the Covid waves—demand for anti-Covid-19 drugs, antibiotics, vitamins, paracetamol and steroids was high. Subsequently, medication for non-communicable diseases (NCDs), I expect, would be higher than the pre-Covid era,” says Misra.

In addition, according to the IQVIA report, indiscriminate use of treatments

PHARMA MAJORS ARE LOOKING TO RETURN TO THEIR AREAS OF EXPERTISE, WITH THE DEMAND SCENARIO CHANGING

antipyretics, antibiotics and multivitamins still have a healthy market. There is also muted demand for the much-hyped antiviral drug Molnupiravir, which at least 13 firms—including Sun Pharma, Cipla and Dr. Reddy’s—are manufacturing. Meanwhile, the growth in non-Covid-19 categories is being driven by an underlying rise in the instances of other illnesses, which is what the companies are now focussing on.

PUBLIC HEALTH EXPERTS indicate that the after-effects of Covid-19 infections have resulted in a sharp increase in cases of neurological, endocrine, diabetes-related, respiratory and dermatological complications, a trend that is set to heighten the consumption of drugs for the treatment of these diseases. A report by American global data science firm IQVIA shows that India has over 15.5 million Covid-cured patients who will have long-term health consequences—technically called long-Covid—the second highest after the US’s 19.1 million (in all, the global total is 104.6 million).

“We are witnessing new cases of onset of diabetes after

such as steroids had led to an increase in black fungus cases in India and perhaps an increase in the incidence of acute vascular necrosis of bones (death of bone tissue due to a lack of blood supply) in the post-Covid-19 period, leading to patients needing intensive care, including intubation.

With the demand scenario changing, Indian pharma majors are now scrambling to return to their areas of expertise. For instance, Dr. Reddy’s Laboratories, the main distributor of Russian Covid-19 vaccine Sputnik, is now focussing on its core businesses of APIs or active pharmaceutical ingredients (a biologically active constituent of a drug), generics, branded generics, biosimilars (these are identical copies of original drugs manufactured by different companies), and over-the-counter (OTC) drugs. These constitute the company’s